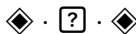


The Shadow Lives in Your Body

Polyvagal theory teaches us that the body keeps score in ways the conscious mind cannot access. When a child is shamed for crying, the **event** may be forgotten, but the nervous system remembers—and tightens the throat every time vulnerability arises. When rage is punished, it does not vanish; it calcines into chronic tension in the jaw, the fists, the shoulders. The body becomes an archaeological site, layered with fossilized emotions waiting to be unearthed.

This is the promise of **somatic shadow work**: you do not need to remember the story to release the holding pattern. The body speaks a language older than words. A sensation in the chest is not just a feeling—it is **data**. A tightening in the belly is not anxiety; it is your gut-brain signaling: **something here needs attention**.

When you learn to translate these signals, you reclaim power. The shadow no longer hijacks you in moments of stress. Instead, it becomes a messenger, a guide, a collaborator in your own wholeness.



Where the Shadow Hides in Your Body:

- **The Throat:** Silenced truth, unexpressed grief, swallowed words.
- **The Chest/Heart:** Abandoned longing, unmetabolized loss, numbness.
- **The Belly/Gut:** Shame, fear, the “knot” of chronic anxiety.
- **The Jaw:** Suppressed anger, grinding self-restraint, protective vigilance.
- **The Shoulders:** The weight of responsibility, armoring against the world.

As you move through this journal, you will be asked again and again: **“Where do you feel this?”** This is not metaphorical. It is cartographic. You are mapping the geography of your own soul.

The work begins now.